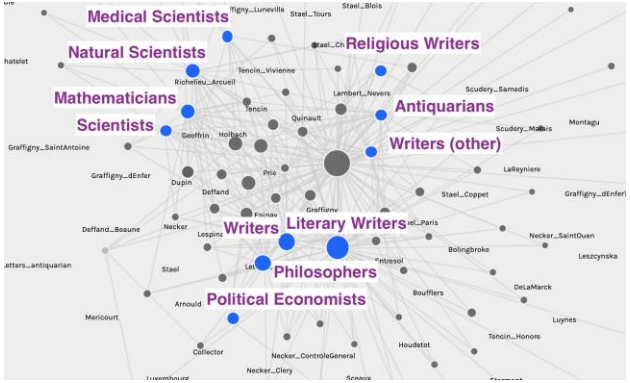
World 18th Century Writers in Wikidata



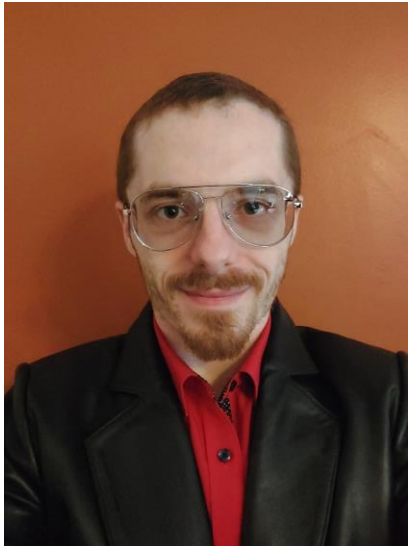
Melanie Conroy and Hunter Brau

Computational Humanities
University of Chicago, 2026

THE UNIVERSITY OF MEMPHIS

Collaborators

Melanie Conroy
World Languages
and Literatures



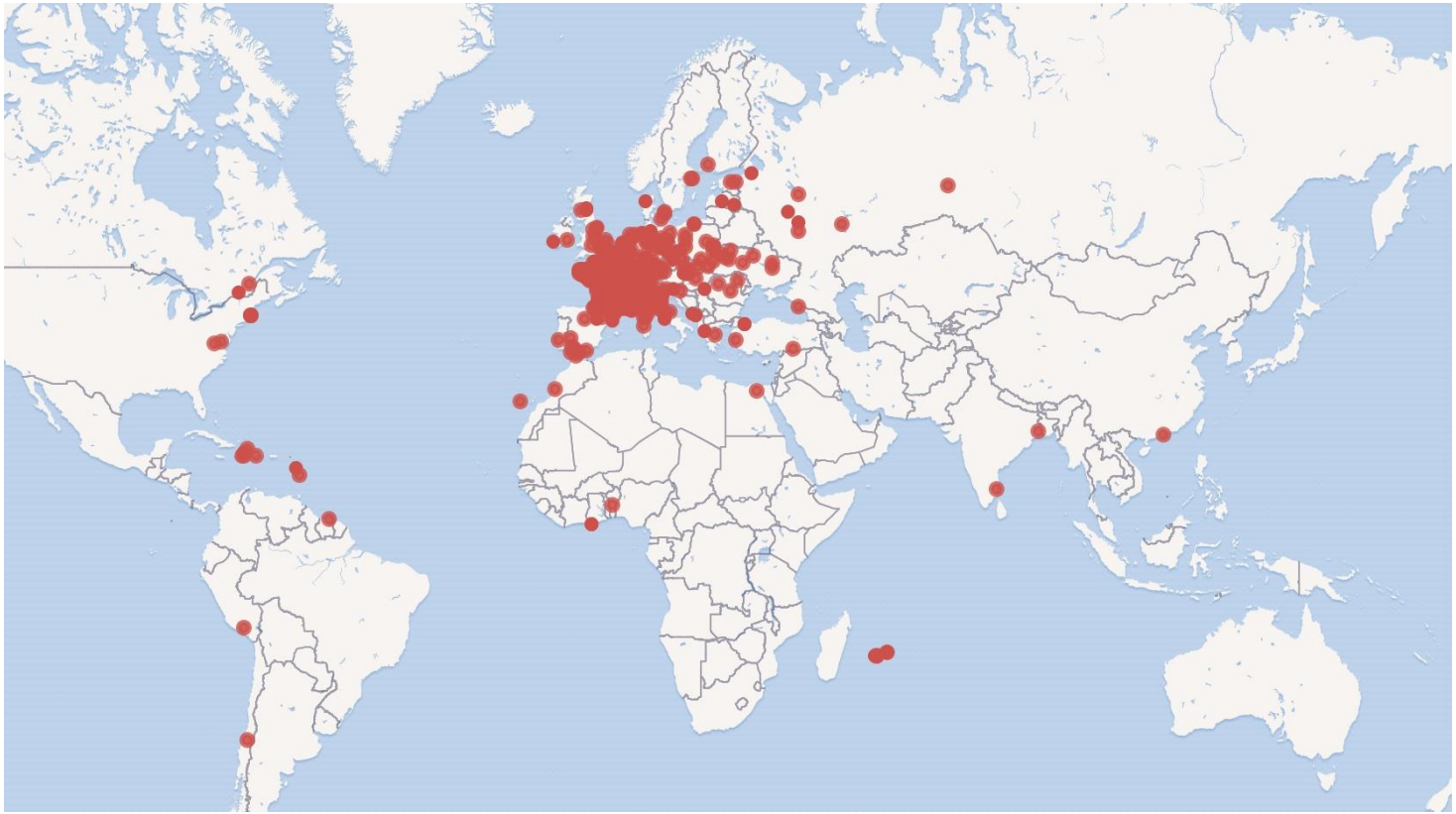
Hunter Brau
World Languages
And Computer Science

THE UNIVERSITY OF MEMPHIS

```
# Map of birthplaces of writers (all subclasses) born between 1675 and 1775
SELECT ?writer ?writerLabel ?birthDate ?birthPlace ?birthPlaceLabel ?coords WHERE {

  ?writer wdt:P31 wd:Q5;                    # instance of human
          wdt:P569 ?birthDate;              # date of birth
          wdt:P106/wdt:P279* wd:Q36180;     # occupation: writer or subclass
          wdt:P19 ?birthPlace.              # place of birth

  # Get coordinates of birthplace
  ?birthPlace wdt:P625 ?coords.

  # Date filter
  FILTER(YEAR(?birthDate) >= 1675 && YEAR(?birthDate) <= 1775)

  # Labels
  SERVICE wikibase:label {
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "en".
  }
}
ORDER BY ?birthDate
```

SPARQL Query for 18-Century Writers of all Nationalities and Cultures with Birthplaces in Wikidata

18-Century Writers of all Nationalities and Cultures with Birthplaces in Wikidata



18-Century French Writers with Birthplaces in Wikidata

Old Slides

Open Data / Linked Data

Wikidata Unique Identifiers for Persons

Instance of	human	Q5	common name of Homo sapiens, unique extant species of the genus Homo
sex or gender	Male, female, intersex, transgender male, transgender female	P21	sex or gender identity of human or animal. For human: male, female, non-binary, intersex, transgender female, transgender male, agender. For animal: male organism, female organism. Groups of same gender use subclass of (P279)
occupation	Writer, salonnière, poet, playwright, etc	P106	occupation of a person; see also "field of work" (Property:P101), "position held" (Property:P39)

- contains birthplace, birth date
- places are linked to open-source geographical data + coordinates
- contains nationality, gender
- contains “activities”
- linked to family members, teachers, students, etc.
- for authors, contains books, genres

Marie-Thérèse Rodet Geoffrin

15 langues

Pour les articles homonymes, voir Rodet.

Marie-Thérèse Rodet Geoffrin, née le 26 juin 1699 à Paris, où elle est morte le 6 octobre 1777[3], est une salonnière française.

Biographie [modifier | modifier le code]

Fille d’un valet de chambre de Marie Anne de Bavière, dauphine de France, Marie-Thérèse Rodet était une femme d’esprit issue de la petite bourgeoisie. Son père, malgré sa charge de valet de garde-robe, ne put faire grande fortune car la Dauphine vivait en recluse à Versailles et mourut jeune. Néanmoins, revenu à Paris, il put faire construire un hôtel pour 30 000 livres et placer à bon escient 100 000 livres de rentes. Elle était sans grande instruction. Sa mère mourant jeune, elle fut élevée par sa grand-mère, madame Chemineau, qui ne lui donna pas d'éducation formelle, mais lui apprit l'art de la conversation.

Sa grand-mère la fit épouser à quatorze ans[4] le lieutenant-colonel de la Milice de Paris, Pierre François Geoffrin, issu comme elle de famille bourgeoise, mais qui était riche (richesse acquise dans l'industrie et non de son premier mariage comme le racontent certaines chroniques), car directeur de la Manufacture royale de glaces de miroirs[5] du faubourg Saint-Antoine. La jeunesse de Marie-Thérèse Rodet était celle d’une bourgeoise destinée à une existence terne lorsqu’elle caressa le rêve, en apparence fort prétentieux, de lancer un salon, rêve qu’elle finit par transformer en réalité vers 1727-1730. Comme elle avait, elle aussi, quelque fortune, elle se donna le plaisir de recevoir gens de lettres, ministres et ambassadeurs et commença à se faire bien voir dans le monde. Néanmoins Monsieur Geoffrin n'appréciait que très modérément ces dépenses.

Elle forma son esprit en côtoyant les personnalités fréquentant le salon de Madame de Tencin où Fontenelle l’avait introduite, et dont elle recueillit les hôtes à la mort de

Marie-Thérèse Rodet Geoffrin

Jean-Marc Nattier, *Portrait de Madame Geoffrin*, 1738 (Musée d'art Fuji de Toyko (en))[1]

Biographie

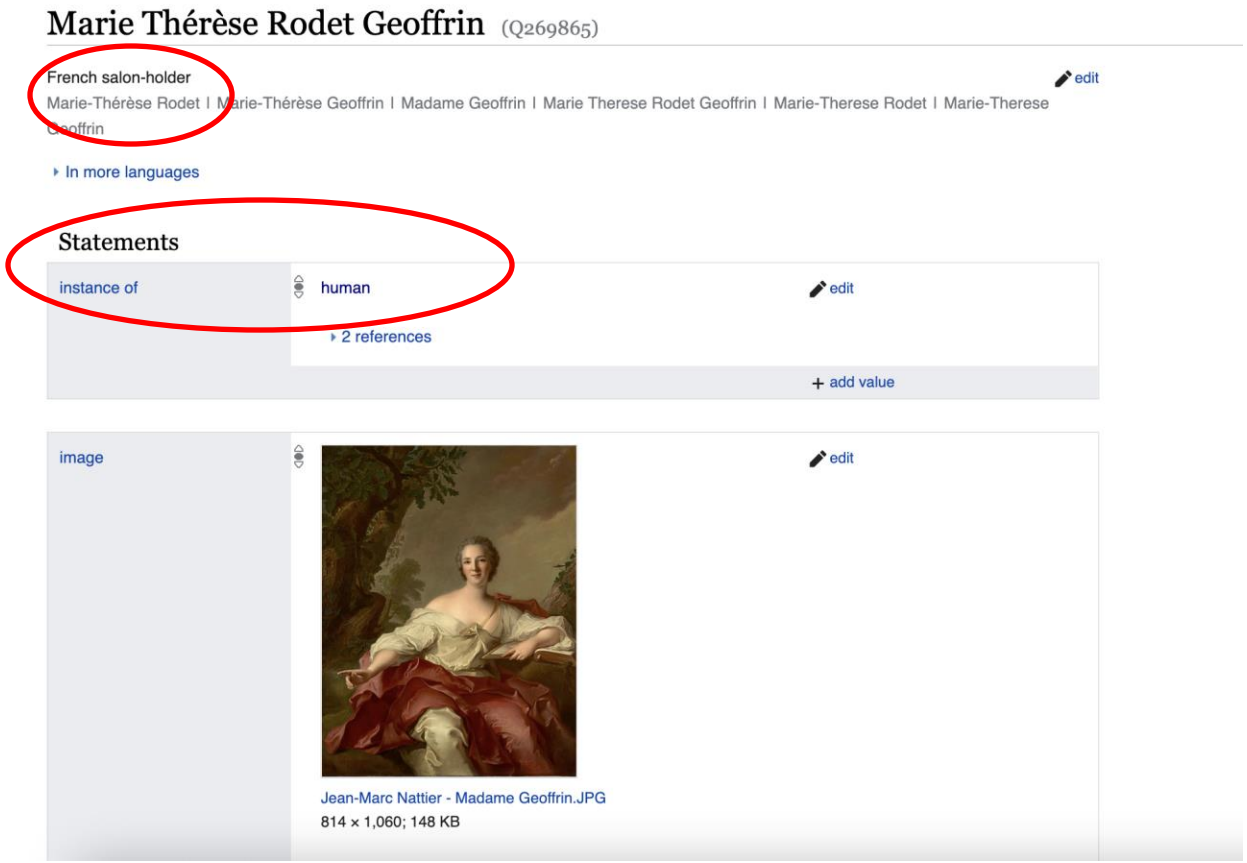
Naissance	26 juin 1699 Paris
Décès	6 octobre 1777 (à 78 ans) Paris
Sépulture	Église Saint-Roch

- contains statements about the person, sometimes hundreds

- places contain links to media like images, people associated with the place, associated places, etc

- contains authority files like VIAF and links to library data

- buildings often linked to architectural databases like the Base Mérimée



Wikidata Query Service (SPARQL)

Wikidata Query Service | Examples | Query Builder | Help | More tools | English

```
# writers born after 1935, who wrote in French and spoke or signed German

SELECT DISTINCT ?item ?itemLabel WHERE {
  SERVICE wikibase:label { bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "[AUTO_LANGUAGE]". }
  {
    SELECT DISTINCT ?item WHERE {
      ?item p:P6886 ?statement0.
      ?statement0 (ps:P6886/(wdt:P279*)) wd:Q150.
      ?item p:P106 ?statement1.
      ?statement1 (ps:P106/(wdt:P279*)) wd:Q36180.
      ?item p:P569 ?statement_2.
      ?statement_2 psv:P569 ?statementValue_2.
      ?statementValue_2 wikibase:timePrecision ?precision_2.
      hint:Prior hint:rangeSafe "true"^^xsd:boolean.
      FILTER(?precision_2 >= 9 )
      ?statementValue_2 wikibase:timeValue ?P569_2.
      hint:Prior hint:rangeSafe "true"^^xsd:boolean.
      FILTER(?P569_2 >= "+1936-00-00T00:00:00Z"^^xsd:dateTime)
      ?item p:P1412 ?statement3.
      ?statement3 (ps:P1412/(wdt:P279*)) wd:Q188.
    }
    LIMIT 1000
  }
}
```

-SPARQL is a simplified language for querying databases.

- Can still be difficult for new users

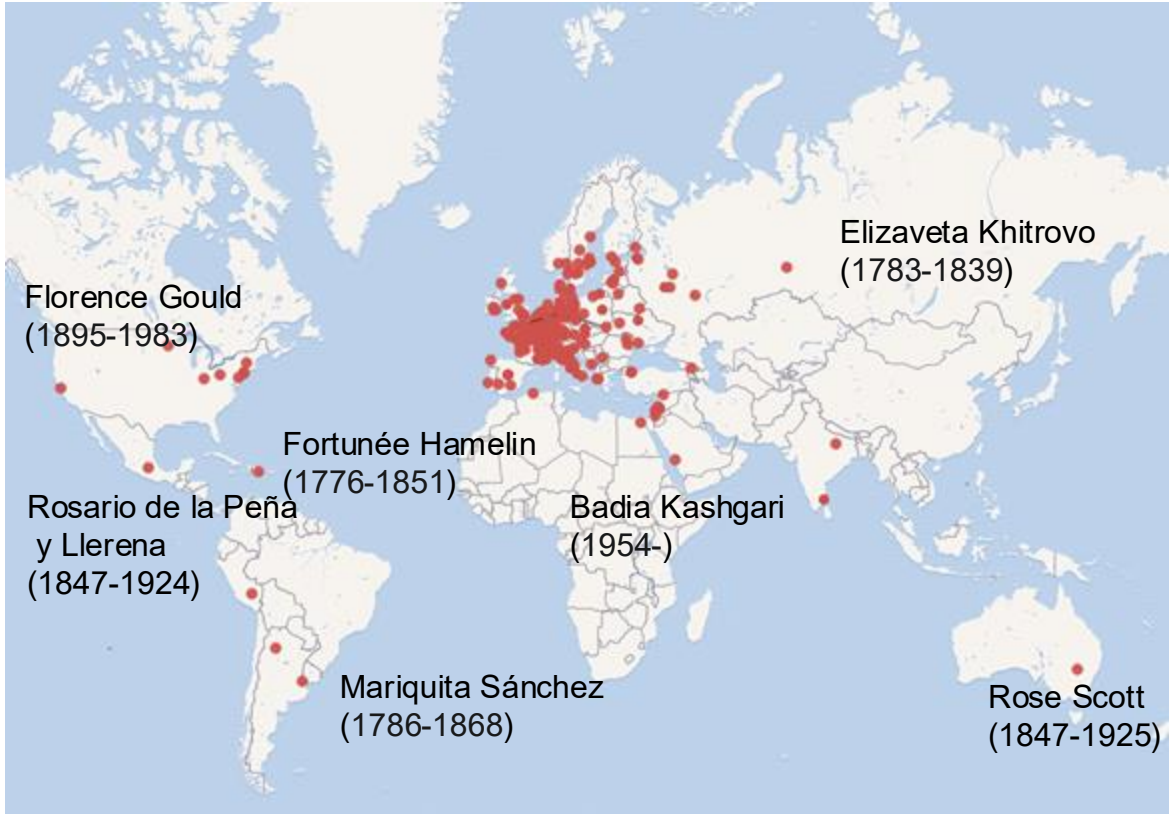
Query for “salonnière” on Wikidata

Wikidata Query Service | Examples | Help | More tools | Query Builder | English

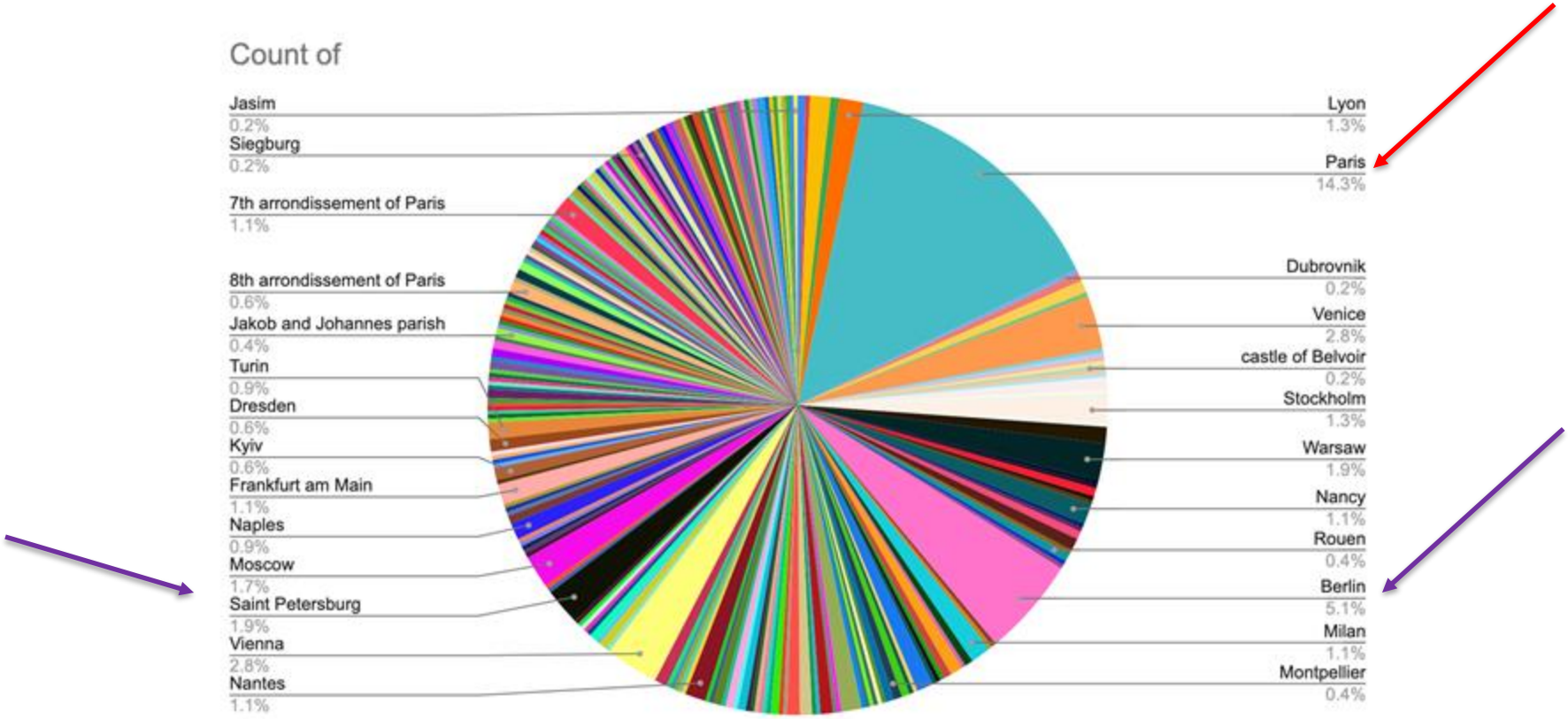
```
#Map of birth places of salonnières
SELECT DISTINCT ?item ?itemLabel ?placeofbirth ?coord ?dob
WHERE {
?item wdt:P31 wd:Q5. #find humans
?item wdt:P21 wd:Q6581072. #who are women
?item wdt:P106/wdt:P279* wd:Q3068305. #with the profession of salonnière
OPTIONAL {?item wdt:P19 ?placeofbirth. #check for place of birth and find coordinates
?placeofbirth wdt:P625 ?coord.}
OPTIONAL {?item wdt:P569 ?dob.} #check for date of birth
 }
#defaultView:Map
```

Map | 549 results in 344 ms | Code | Download | Link

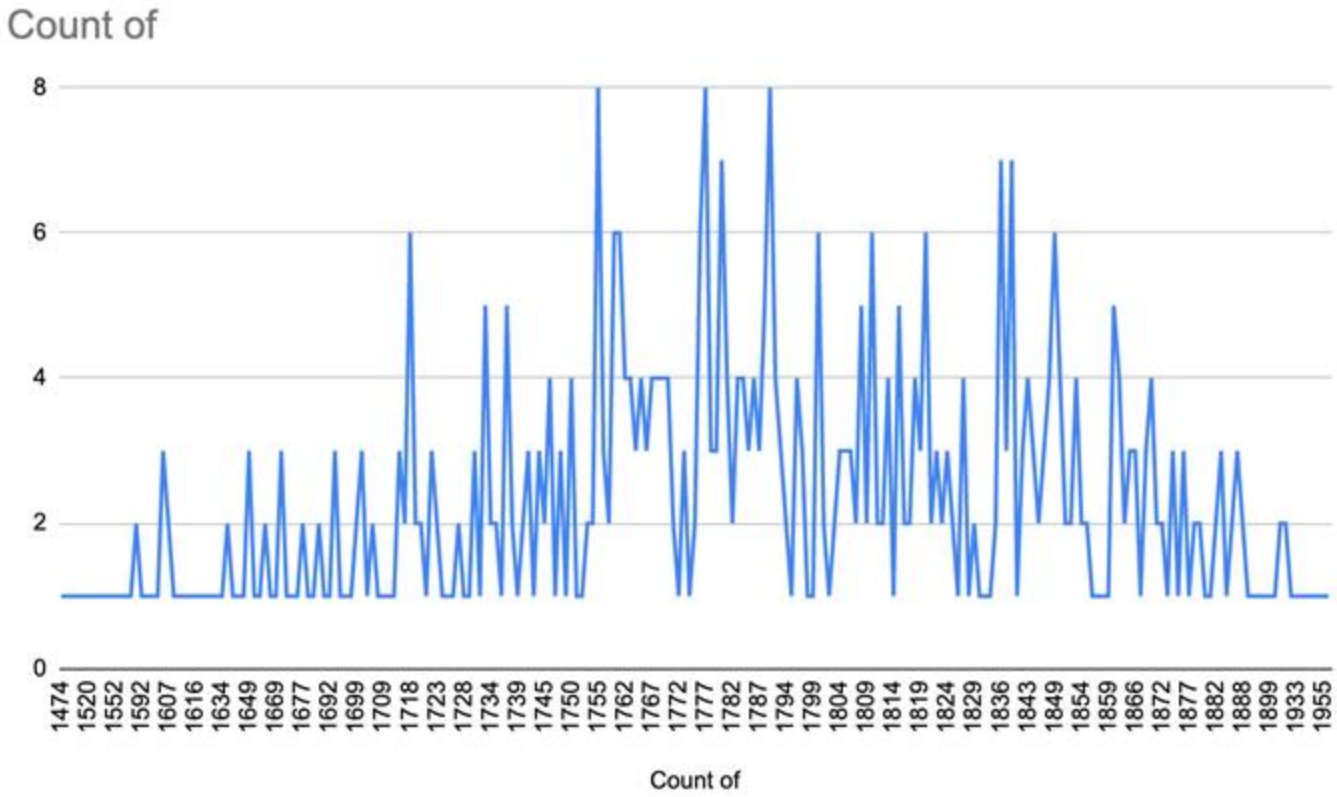
Map of Birth Places of salonnières



Birth places of salonnières



Birth years of salonnières



Lesson plan

Warm-up

1. Ask students what they use AI and Wikipedia for.
2. Have students brainstorm uses for AI on the topic of the course.

Plan of Work

3. Put students in groups and have them come up with at least 3 ideas for questions that AI could answer.
4. Let each group choose one idea to translate into a question that Wikidata could answer.
5. Have students instruct Chat GPT to use Canvas, then, create one prompt and input it to ChatGPT.
6. Students copy and paste the SPARQL script into the Wikidata query service.

Reflection

7. Did ChatGPT retrieve the right items or was there any error or oversight in the query? If that error can be fixed easily, ask ChatGPT to revise the script and input that into the Wikidata query service.

ChatGPT Prompt: write a SPARQL script for use in the Wikidata query service that queries Wikidata for Icelandic poets

Wikidata Query Service | Examples | Help | More tools | Query Builder | English

```
SELECT DISTINCT ?poet ?poetLabel WHERE {
  ?poet wdt:P31 wd:Q5;                # Instance of human
        wdt:P106 wd:Q49757;           # Occupation: poet
        wdt:P27 wd:Q189.               # Country of citizenship: Iceland

  SERVICE wikibase:label {            # Get labels in English
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "en".
  }
}
```

Table | 201 results in 440 ms | Code | Download | Link

ChatGPT Prompt: write a SPARQL script for use in the Wikidata query service that queries Wikidata for Icelandic poets

```
SELECT DISTINCT ?poet ?poetLabel WHERE {
 ?poet wdt:P31 wd:Q5;          # Instance of human
      wdt:P106 wd:Q49757;      # Occupation: poet
      wdt:P27 wd:Q189.         # Country of citizenship: Iceland

 SERVICE wikibase:label {      # Get labels in English
  bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "en".
 }
}
```

Your SPARQL query is correctly structured to return all **distinct Icelandic poets** in Wikidata, with English labels.

Here's a cleaned-up, clearly formatted version for readability:

sparql Copy Edit

```sparql
SELECT DISTINCT ?poet ?poetLabel WHERE {
  ?poet wdt:P31 wd:Q5;          # instance of human
        wdt:P106 wd:Q49757;     # occupation: poet
        wdt:P27 wd:Q189.        # country of citizenship: Iceland
```

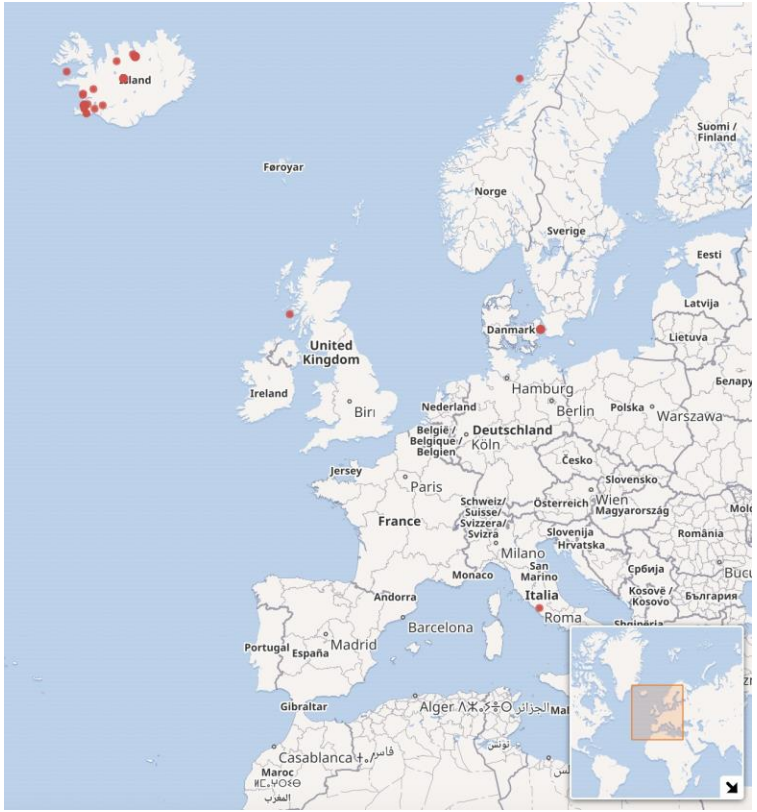
If you wanted **only dead Icelandic poets**, you'd just add the "date of death" property filter:

sparql Copy Edit

```sparql
SELECT DISTINCT ?poet ?poetLabel WHERE {
  ?poet wdt:P31 wd:Q5;
        wdt:P106 wd:Q49757;
        wdt:P27 wd:Q189;
        wdt:P570 ?dateOfDeath.   # must have a date of death

  SERVICE wikibase:label {
    bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "en".
  }
}
```

Do you want me to also make it return **birth and death years** so it's easier to see their lifespan? That can be useful for filtering and sorting.

ChatGPT Prompt: write a SPARQL script for use in the Wikidata query service that queries Wikidata for Icelandic poets who have known birthplaces and coordinates



ChatGPT Prompt: change the nationality of to Austrian and delete the occupation of poet and add musician as the occupation

```
DISTINCT ?musician ?musicianLabel ?birthDate ?deathDate WHERE {
?musician wdt:P31 wd:Q5;          # Instance of human
wdt:P106 wd:Q639669;    # Occupation: musician
wdt:P27 wd:Q40;         # Country of citizenship: Austria
wdt:P569 ?birthDate;    # Date of birth
wdt:P570 ?deathDate.    # Date of death

SERVICE wikibase:label { bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "[AUTO_LANGUAGE],en". }
}
ORDER BY ?birthDate
```

324 results in 2431 ms

ChatGPT Prompt: modify the current SPARQL script to find Austrian musicians on the German Wikidata and to retrieve German-language names and other labels

Wikidata Query Service | Examples | Help | More tools | Query Builder | English

```
SELECT DISTINCT ?musician ?musicianLabel ?birthDate ?deathDate WHERE {
?musician wdt:P31 wd:Q5;          # Instanz Mensch
wdt:P106 wd:Q639669;    # Beruf: Musiker
wdt:P27 wd:Q40;         # Staatsangehörigkeit: Österreich
wdt:P569 ?birthDate;    # Geburtsdatum
wdt:P570 ?deathDate.    # Sterbedatum

SERVICE wikibase:label { bd:serviceParam wikibase:language "de". }
}
ORDER BY ?birthDate
```

Table | 324 results in 7039 ms | Code | Download | Link

Strengths and Weaknesses in ChatGPT's SPARQL Queries

Strengths

- Users do not need to be familiar with the **hundreds of unique identifiers** that would be related to their research question.
- Users can easily **revise scripts** that do not work or are too simple using natural language.
- Speed of use and **iteration**.
- **Vast quantity of data** linked to even relatively rare items or persons.

Weaknesses

- When the query is written in English, ChatGPT writes scripts that **only consider English-language Wikidata** (by default, since this can be changed).
- The workflow is not too overwhelming but there are more potential for **versioning problems** with ChatGPT Canvas because it only provides one output.
- ChatGPT has **hallucinations** and sometimes invents information like properties and statements.

Thanks!

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